Present Perfect vs. Simple Past

Present Perfect Tense

Form: have/has + past participle (V3)

Uses: For action started in the past and connected to the present in one of these ways

1. **To talk about experiences in life (time not specified)**
    - I have visited Kenya. (I did this at some time in my life.)
    - She has eaten sushi before. (She experienced it in her life.)
    - I have never tried Ethiopian traditional dancing. (No experience in life.)
    - He has ridden a horse. (He has the experience.)
2. **To describe an action that started in the past and continues to the present**
    - She has lived in Addis Ababa **for** 10 years. *(She still lives there)*
    - He has known me since childhood. (He knew me in the past and still knows me.)
    - They have worked at this company for five years. (They began five years ago and still work here.)
    - I have studied English since 2010. (I started in 2010, and I still study now.)
3. **Recently ended actions**
    - He has just finished his homework. (My homework is done moment ago)
    - I have just arrived home. (I came home a moment ago.)
    - We have recently moved to a new house. (We moved not long ago.)
    - The movie has just started**. (**It began a moment ago)
4. **Finished action with present influence**
    - She has broken her leg. (She can't walk now.)
    - Someone has stolen my phone. (I don't have it now.)
    - The teacher has explained the lesson. (We understand it now.)
    - I have already eaten. (I am not hungry now.)

Signal Words:

- ever, never, already, just, yet, recently, so far, since, fo

Examples:

- They **have eaten** breakfast.
- I **have known** her since 2015.
- She **has already finished** her assignment.

Simple Past Tense

Form: V2 (past form of verb)

Uses: for action completely ended in the past with following situations

1. **To talk about completed actions in the past (specific time)**
    - I visited Kenya **last year**.
2. **Finished time expressions**
    - yesterday, last week, in 2010, two days ago
3. **Past habitual (repeated action in the past)**
    - She used to play piano when she was a child.

Examples:

- They ate breakfast at 7 AM.
- I knew her in high school.
- She finished her assignment yesterday.
- He used to smoke**,** but he quit.

Difference between present perfect and simple past

Present Perfect	**Simple Past**
Time is **not specific**	Time is **specific**
Focus on result/experience	Focus on past event/time
e.g., I have seen that movie.	e.g., I saw that movie yesterday.

Exercise

A. Choose the correct form

1. She (has lived / lived) in Ethiopia since 2016.
2. I (have finished / finished) my work two hours ago.
3. They (have never been / never were) to Japan.
4. He (has broken / broke) his leg last month.
5. We (have just arrived / just arrived) home.

B. Fill in the blanks using Present Perfect or Simple Past.

1. I _____ (visit) my grandparents last weekend.
2. She _____ (live) in Addis Ababa since 2018.
3. They _____ (finish) their homework already.
4. We _____ (go) to that museum yesterday.
5. He _____ (not / see) that movie yet.
6. I _____ (meet) him two years ago.
7. She _____ (just / arrive) home.
8. They _____ (study) English when they were children.
9. He _____ (break) his leg last month.
10. I _____ (not / eat) breakfast this morning; I'm still hungry.